



Seed head opens when the parachutes are formed

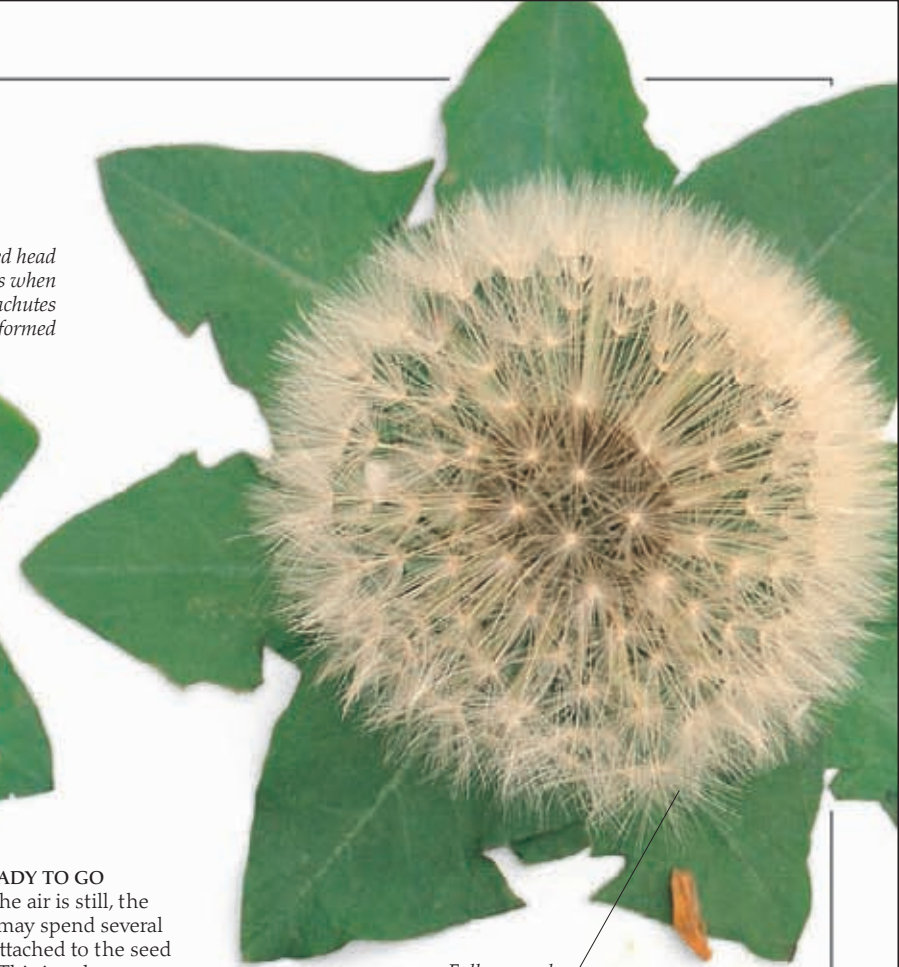
Bracts fold back

3 OPENING OUT

The seed head begins to open only when the weather is dry. At first, the parachutes are squashed together, but as the bracts around the edge of the seed head fold back, the parachutes begin to expand.

4 READY TO GO

If the air is still, the fruits may spend several days attached to the seed head. This is a dangerous time for them, because seed-eating birds such as goldfinches are likely to peck them off and eat them.



Fully opened seed head



Parachutes attached to tiny fruits

5 LIFTOFF

A slight breeze is all that is needed to lift the parachutes into the air. They may fall close by, but if there is enough updraft they can be carried for long distances. When a fruit lands, it no longer needs the parachute that has carried it on its journey, and this breaks off. Over the winter the seed sinks into the soil, waiting for the spring when it begins to germinate.